

100 Days of Linux - Day 012

Title: Viewing the Beginning of Files with head

Today's Goal

Learn how to display the first few lines of a file using the **head** command.

Why This Matters

Data engineers and developers often inspect the first few rows of CSV files, log files, and configuration files before processing them.

Command of the Day: head

Syntax: head filename

Common Option: head -n 5 filename (show first 5 lines)

Explanation: Displays the beginning of a text file.

Examples:

```
head employees.csv
```

```
head -n 3 notes.txt
```

Beginner Lesson

Unlike **cat**, which displays the entire file, **head** is useful when you only want to inspect the beginning of a file. This is especially helpful when working with large datasets.

Practice Questions

1. Create a file named fruits.txt with at least 10 lines of text, then display the first 10 lines using head.
2. Display only the first 5 lines of fruits.txt.
3. Create a file named employees.txt with at least 8 lines and display the first 3 lines.
4. Navigate to another directory and use head to view the beginning of a text file there.
5. Display your current working directory after completing today's tasks.

Hints

Use any method you know to create a text file with multiple lines. Then practice both 'head filename' and 'head -n number filename'.

Mini Challenge

Create a file named students.txt containing 15 names. Display the first 10 lines, then display only the first 4 lines.

Common Mistakes

Using head on an empty file. If the file has no content, nothing will be displayed.

Did You Know?

By default, the head command displays the first 10 lines of a file.

Pro Tip

The head command is very useful for quickly checking whether a CSV file has the expected column headers.

Answer Key (Instructor Only)

Q1: head fruits.txt

Q2: head -n 5 fruits.txt

Q3: head -n 3 employees.txt

Q4: cd && head filename

Q5: pwd

Homework

Create three different text files and practice displaying the first 2, 5, and 10 lines using head.

Next Day Preview

Tomorrow you'll learn the tail command to display the last few lines of a file.